AI Documentation Zero Draft Public Comment Template

Commenters on the initial public draft for the Zero Draft on AI Documentation are encouraged to use this template to provide feedback to NIST.

As noted in the draft document, comments are welcome on any aspect of the draft, particularly the issues raised in the blue boxes. Submissions will become part of the public record and may be subject to public disclosure.

Commenter information

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Comments by clause

Instructions: The table below is for comments on specific portions of the draft. For these comments, please indicate in the left column what clause or subclause the comment addresses, and provide the comment, including any suggested changes, in the right column as free text. NIST particularly welcomes specific suggestions for replacement text, where applicable. Create new rows as needed.

Example entries:

Clause/subclause (as specific as applicable)	**Comment**
Clause 3.5.2	Replace “happy” with “glad.”
Clauses 4.7 and 4.8	Consider combining these clauses. The distinction between them is not strong, and indeed there are edge cases, such as real-time social media video filters, that fall into both categories. The texts of the two clauses could be combined as follows: <Suggested text>

Appendix D	This appendix contains critical information that should be part of the main body. We suggest moving it to become Clause 7.

Your comments

Clause/subclause (as specific as applicable)	**Comment**
Annex A, Table A.2.1, Field 4.8.1 (Annotation)	Over the past year, I participated as a Korean language specialist and a legal expert in multiple AI annotation projects. The provided annotation guidelines differed in two main points: language and coverage. All projects' data under annotation were in multiple languages including English, but the annotation guidelines were written in English. **Language**: Non-English versions of the guidelines were rarely provided. Even in the rare cases where they were provided, they were literal translations. **Coverage**: While coverage was mostly a detailed description from the overall framework to specific examples, there were a few cases where only the style and format were specified. In the latter case, calibration points were communicated informally within each work group (e.g., verbal instructions or chat messages) when specific cases raised questions. These were not incorporated back into the guidelines document, and much of the substantive judgment was left to the annotators' discretion. Whether guidelines specified substantive judgment criteria or left them to discretion is a property of the dataset itself. Labels produced under discretionary guidelines reflect the judgment distribution of the annotator pool; labels produced under specified criteria reflect those criteria. They are not the same dataset. Field 4.8.1 currently asks documenters to describe annotation guidelines but does not specify what to describe. All of the differences above can be reported as "guidelines were provided," and since the distinction is not required, no comparability across organizations arises. Where the reports this draft already asks for are included, an interpretation problem follows: in label consistency analyses (5.1, conditionally required), handling of mislabeled instances (4.9, optional), and

	inter-annotator agreement methodology (4.8.1.1, recommended), agreement under guidelines that specify substantive criteria and agreement under style-only guidelines measure different things, yet the documentation does not distinguish them. **I propose adding subfield 4.8.1.2 to describe the coverage of the guidelines, the language(s) in which they were provided, and how non-English versions were produced.** Field 4.8.1.1 already gives annotators a separate entry; this gives the state of the guidelines the same treatment. The information is already known to the provider organization and can be reported without new investigation (per 4.1, internal documentation is typically more thorough than what is released publicly), and a single enumerated line keeps the reporting burden minimal. The addition enables readers to determine what reported metrics measured and how much evidential weight they can bear, improving suitability assessment (3.3.1.2). If a new subfield is excessive, a fallback is adding a sentence to the Additional Guidance and Requirements column of 4.8.1 asking documenters to cover the same three items. **Suggested replacement text (new row in Table A.2.1):** **ID:** 4.8.1.2 **Field Name:** Guideline Language and Coverage **Description:** Information describing the coverage of the annotation guidelines (whether they specify the substantive judgment criteria for the task or only style and formatting conventions), the language(s) in which the guidelines were provided relative to the data under annotation, and how non-English versions were produced **Designation:** Recommended **Additional Guidance and Requirements:** May be reported as a single enumerated line. For coverage, classify by whether the guidelines specify task-level judgment criteria (what to decide) or only style and formatting conventions (how to write). For production of non-English versions, classify by whether drafting started from the English original text: none / literal translation / rewritten with reference to the original / independently authored per language. Example: "Guideline language(s): English original only; the data

	under annotation included Korean and other languages. Non-English versions: none provided. Coverage: style and formatting only; substantive judgment criteria were conveyed verbally within work groups and not incorporated into the document."
Annex A, Table A.2.1, Field 4.8.1.1 (Annotators)	The handling of disagreements and ambiguous cases also differed across the projects: a standing dispute procedure or ad-hoc announcements and instructions. What was measured as agreement also varied: preference rankings, overall scores, or binary preferences. Furthermore, in projects where the QC/Audit phase reviewed and modified the two annotators' responses, the responses eventually converged to the same answer except in extremely ambiguous cases. In such projects, agreement measured before the QC/Audit phase and agreement measured after it are not the same metric: the former reflects the extent to which tasks and guidelines are reproducible in independent judgments; the latter reflects the operation of the QC/Audit procedure. The current description, "methodology regarding inter-annotator agreement," does not specify what the methodology includes. The note at the head of Annex A invites input on how best to clarify the intended content of each field so that documenters can populate it consistently. **I propose clarifying that the intended content of this field includes:** (1) what was measured as agreement (label agreement, preference agreement, or scores); (2) when agreement was measured (at independent judgment, or after QC and revision); and (3) the procedure for resolving disagreements and who held final judgment authority. Both measurement points are worth reporting, but unless the documentation states which one was reported, readers cannot determine what the number supports. (This field and the 4.8.1.2 subfield proposed above together make reported metrics interpretable.)
Annex A, Table A.3.1, Field 6.1 (Evaluation methodology)	The Additional Guidance for 6.1 asks documenters to clarify which evaluation methods are automated and which are performed by humans, but does not ask for the language conditions of evaluation: the language(s) in which evaluations were conducted, and whether evaluation inputs were originally authored in those

	languages or translated. Machine translation rendering is not deterministic: I have observed the same Korean phrase rendered at different severity levels by different translation tools. Inputs at different severity levels test different things, so which rendering an evaluation ran on is a pipeline fact needed to interpret its results. Without the language conditions, readers assessing multilingual deployment cannot determine the scope of the evaluation results (3.3.1.2). **I propose adding one sentence to the Additional Guidance and Requirements column of 6.1, parallel to the existing automated/human clarification**: "Should state the language(s) in which evaluations were conducted; whether evaluation inputs were originally authored in those languages or translated, including the translation method; and for human evaluations, the language(s) in which outputs were reviewed." (On the language state of annotation guidelines, see the comment on 4.8.1.)
Annex A.1 (lines 712–713 and 719–720)	The text refers to the risk and impact analysis subfield of Table A.2.1 as "Field 5.1"; in Table A.2.1, 5.1 is Data Analysis and the risk and impact subfield is 5.3. **Replace "5.1" with "5.3"**.
Annex A.2 (lines 722–723)	The text introduces Table A.2.1 as "a list of fields from Clause 5.3"; Table A.2.1 corresponds to the dataset template in Clause 5.2. **Replace "5.3" with "5.2"**.
Clause 3.4.5 (lines 352–353)	The text refers to the qualities of documentation artifacts as "Clause 4.3"; these qualities are described in Clause 4.2. **Replace "4.3" with "4.2"**.
Note to Reviewers following line 697 (head of Annex A)	The note asks how changes "would improve both outcomes along the dimensions in Clause 4"; the outcome dimensions are defined in Clause 3. **Replace "Clause 4" with "Clause 3"**.
Clause 2 (Terms and definitions): "public-facing"	Minor comment. The term "public-facing," which appears in the title, is not defined in Clause 2. Clause 4.1 distinguishes public, limited external, and internal audiences, but only in prose. I propose adding a definition to Clause 2 and connecting it to the three-way distinction in 4.1.
Clause 2, "documentation artifact" (note at line 153)	Minor comment. "Artifact" pairs naturally with "documentation process" as its produced output. In ML practice, however, "artifact" commonly refers to build outputs and model weights ("model artifacts"), a

	collision frequent in exactly this document's audience. The definition itself reads "record describing a product or service"; I suggest "documentation record" as an alternative.

Document-wide comments

Instructions: This section is for comments that pertain to the entire document, not specific clauses or subclauses. Create new rows as needed.

These comments respond to the requests in the Notes to Reviewers, in particular the request for views on explicit links between the fields in Clause 5 and Annex A and the guidance in Clause 4. Their common point: the conditions under which annotation judgments are made are invisible in current documentation, and they become practically useful when translated into documentation requirements. Each comment above is a field-level instance of that translation.
On examples (note at line 618): I recommend inline filled-in examples in the Additional Guidance column over complete example artifacts in separate annexes, which carry maintenance costs as the document ages (4.4.3). The proposed row for 4.8.1.2 above includes such an example.
Disclosure of AI use: I used an AI assistant (Claude) extensively: for analyzing the draft's structure, mapping practical observations to the relevant fields, verifying literature and field citations, drafting the portions outside the experience-based passages, and assembling the submission document. The practical observations and positions that ground these comments are my own; I wrote those passages myself, and AI editing of them was limited to grammar and terminology consistency.

Attachment: Field-level drafts for models updated after deployment (seed of a specialized "Embodied AI Profile")

For models that continue to learn or be updated after deployment, and for models whose behavior arises in coupling with hardware and environment, the static documentation premise breaks at three points: the validity period of evaluations, the one-to-many divergence of deployed instances, and lineage. Clause 6 opens profiles to specialization by anyone. The field-level drafts below are written against Table A.3.1; they could be incorporated into the default model profile, or serve as the seed of a specialized profile for such models (an "Embodied AI Profile").

A-1. Annex A, Table A.3.1, Field 7.2 (Update Mechanisms): new subfield 7.2.1 Continual Learning Status

I propose adding subfield 7.2.1 to state whether model weights are updated after deployment.

Rationale: this specializes 7.2 ("how models are retrained"); the current description implies, but does not require stating, whether retraining continues after deployment. Proposed designation for 7.2: raise from Optional to Recommended.

ID: 7.2.1

Field Name: Continual Learning Status

Description: Information stating whether model weights are updated after deployment, and in what form (offline batch retraining or online continual learning)

Designation: Recommended

A-2. Annex A, Table A.3.1, Field 7.7 (Versioning Policy): added guidance and designation

I propose adding guidance to field 7.7 and raising its designation; no new subfield is needed.

Rationale: 7.7 already covers "criteria for or frequency of model updates." Proposed guidance: the units and upper bounds of update frequency, and how irregular updates are to be reported. Proposed designation: conditionally required for models updated after deployment. Distinction: the "how often" in the guidance of 7.2 concerns how often updates are communicated to stakeholders, not how often the model is updated.

A-3. Annex A, Table A.3.1, Field 7.1 (Monitoring Mechanisms): new subfield 7.1.1 Evaluation Validity and Re-evaluation Policy

I propose adding subfield 7.1.1 to state how long evaluation results remain valid and when re-evaluation occurs.

Rationale: this specializes 7.1 ("methods for detecting drift and otherwise re-evaluating"); the current description asks for the methods but not for how long results remain valid or what triggers re-evaluation. In practice, vendor technical documentation already reports post-release behaviors beyond the documented intended use, framed as capability improvements; such reports are exactly what makes evaluation validity finite. Boundary: 6.4 discloses the timing and frequency of evaluations performed; this field states the forward-looking policy for validity and re-evaluation.

ID: 7.1.1

Field Name: Evaluation Validity and Re-evaluation Policy

Description: Information stating the period for which evaluation results remain valid after deployment, and the triggers, frequency, and responsibility for re-evaluation

Designation: Recommended

A-4. Annex A, Table A.3.1, identification fields (1.6, 1.11): item raised without a field draft, tracking the divergence of deployed instances

When deployed copies of a model are updated through different experiences, the current table cannot describe them: 1.6.1 defines identifiers per release, 1.11 (Lineage) points backward to prior models, and "instance" throughout the document refers to data instances. The consequence is concrete: root field 1 requires (Shall) that readers can determine whether a given model is the one described by the documentation artifact, and under instance divergence that determination is no longer possible. I raise this as a subject for future profiles and standardization work.